

Statements

(internal, RU only) for external reviewers just shorten to research walkthrough about what i research; maybe cut other stuff like impact factors etc

Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn

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1 Research

I am in the field of social indicators, quality of life, wellbeing, and life satisfaction. The main journals are *Applied Research in Quality of Life* and *Social Indicators Research*.¹ The main academic/professional organization is International Society for Quality-of-Life Studies (ISQOLS). My field is thinner on theory than other social science, (post-)positivist, quantitative—about patterns, relationships, and effects—but correlational, less causal. (Quasi-)experiments are rare, and there are more descriptions and visualizations than economics and statistics. The field is somewhere between geography, psychology, sociology, and philosophy.²

All research is new in some sense, but my research is more new/original/innovative than most. Many contribute incrementally say by slightly improving a model, adding an interaction or instrumental variables. My contribution is new ideas, I have creative ideas, and then able to find the right data to test them. I was the first to look at several relationships:³ effect of energy use on happiness (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Altman 2019), effect of social v individual religiosity on happiness across countries (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2010), and on trust in the US (Valente and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2021); effect of religiosity on creativity across space (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2015). My social indicators and wellbeing interests have been broad, including politics (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2014), volunteering (Morawski et al. 2022), and agency (D'Italia and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2025).

My main area of research has been urban-rural happiness gradient, a term coined in my early paper on the topic: “An urban-rural happiness gradient” (Berry and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2011). This line of research is not entirely new—it has been studied in a quantitative fashion in a limited way in the 70s and philosophically since antiquity—but mine are the first studies in modern times.⁴ And I have a related line of research looking at livability of places: Okulicz-Kozaryn (2013), Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2019).

My urban-rural happiness gradient research includes careful gradient elaboration (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2016) and theory-rich Okulicz-Kozaryn and Mazelis (2016).

More recently, as the research has matured, I elaborated on the details. I added on generational differences (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2018), and growing-up (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2020). Okulicz-Kozaryn (2023) has used Panel Study of Income Dynamics (PSID) to provide longitudinal evidence of the gradient; and its sister paper Okulicz-Kozaryn (2024) elaborated measurement of happiness. Covid19 has increased urban happiness penalty (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2026). Finally, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2021) shows that urban unhappiness is common across countries.

Now I work with students to explore the gradient further: examined population change instead of level (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2024), and turned to non-WEIRD (Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, and Democratic) societies: India (Deb and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2023), Egypt (Mikhaeil et al. 2024), and Colombia (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2026).

Near future research topic trajectory remains similar: mostly urban-rural happiness gradient and regional happiness. And beyond my home continents of Europe and North America my geographic focus now adds Latin America: Okulicz-Kozaryn (2025). I have several specific ideas, but I keep them secret so I don't get scooped.

I plan to spend more time on grant writing. Grants emerge as critical ingredient in my research agenda. I plan to grow my research group, hire students and post-docs. Also course buy-outs are appealing.

Since 2017, when I have submitted my materials for promotion to associate professor with tenure, I have published 37 peer reviewed articles, including 7 in *Cities*, a journal with impact factor (IF)=7.8⁵ higher than widely considered the top journal in public

¹Journal of Happiness Studies have recently shifted towards positive psychology and happiness economics, in my humble opinion.

²Geography is a notable ingredient as my research intersects with geography: regions, and especially urban-rural gradient. This is a subjective description of the field, or rather sub-field, and this is where I fit it. There are other descriptions and sub-fields, notably positive psychology and happiness economics—they are related but different in important ways. My field is well described by its pioneer, Alex Michalos: Michalos (2014b,a).

³In quantitative way, focusing and elaborating the relationship (not just listing among others or controlling for it). I am inclined to say “started few new lines of research by looking at relationships nobody looked at before” but it seems premature and requiring more time to settle things. Still, you will see in my many papers that the idea is indeed the first of its kind—nobody has looked at the relationship before in this way.

⁴There is a 30-40 year generational gap between mostly 70s and very few in early 80s versus my first study in 2009.

⁵<https://www.scimagojr.com/journalsearch.php?q=16956&tip=sid&clean=0>

administration⁶ in the US, Public Administration Review with IF=6.2⁷. I am also collegial and collaborative—I've coauthored with over 20 authors (Scopus). For detailed scientometrics see Appendix. I have also published # of articles (add lonnie rubia now minor revision) in Social Indicators Research, and # in Applied Research in Quality of Life, both leading/main journals in my field.

⁶I am in the department of public policy and administration.

⁷<https://www.scimagojr.com/journalsearch.php?q=17167&tip=sid&clean=0>

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2 Teaching

publishing with students—academic path: and it works: shourjya sipri, aditi virginia tech, michael ditalia RU camden

Teaching: old fashioned critical thinking, no indoctrination so popular these days

from that response to jargo: prioritize transfer of knowledge and learning, not ornamented ceremony; seems to be working: Eric's email that it works in practice, yanan, prakash, that student that got job at philadelphia school district; dodda. ,etc

Something I have missed as a student, and promised myself I won't do on the other side as an instructor. I have found almost all instruction to be fluffy, ornamented, grandiose presentations, where form took more space than matter. Also that paper in scientometrics. And even transfer of knowledge, seemed like most of it wasn't essential, important, helpful to me—plainly speaking most of the work was waste of time. Now as an instructor I strive to focus only on most important things and teach in most simple and straightforward way and also decrease amount of instruction and increase interaction: discussions, presentations, flip the class etc. I believe that these changes are even more important in current reality: short attention span, mental health problems, AI, etc.

yes we should have fun in class it shouldn't be tedious and gruesome; at least not all of it!

max application and skills acquisition by the student; minimize fluff and format unfortunately many still teach the old way: traditional solemn grandiose as if the goal is to put student in a sense of awe

and to skip the fluff and get to the chase: convey info as efficiently as possible, and this is the key: as sophisticated as practicable so can be used, usefulness; and as simply as possible; utility; like 90% of stuff taught never used just headache; and rather than just knowledge or memorizing stuff; ability to navigate the area and use it; learn by example etc

there is this disconnect and apparent conflict between rigor/old school and brave new world with scant attention social media etc; like profs complaining students don't put in hours and attention to study like in 1980s and students probably like wtf is this dry useless shit that i will never use; again like 50-90 % of teaching is typically bs; i condense it, make it relevant; max utility/usefulness with minimum effort; cut the crap; focus on what's most important in most accessible practical hands on way; learn by doing

Note it is not watering down the curriculum. i provide plenty of extra bonus materials so that it is customized to a student, doesn't overwhelm with unnecessary stuff, but provides enough depth and individual learning path. Seems to work as evidenced by student publications, jobs, and feedback.

I try to guide students individually, in the grand scheme of things teaching is about helping students become who they are, and everyone is a little different.

I make sure i am available and approachable for students spending extra time outside of classroom: working on papers, being accessible via zoom and in person etc including when on sabbatical, eg spring 2026 have 4 students enrolled in my dissertation hours

all my classes encourage and give extra credit for civ eng

also note i largely teach methods classes, which often receive lower evaluations

one highlight is unusually heavy curriculum development. Since coming to Rutgers-Camden in 2012, I have taught over 10 different classes, including developing brand new 3 courses in 2023 for our new data science program

i strive to improve my teaching: that is idt course, reading on it eg nature.com chronicle.com and insidehighered.com

i am updating materials each time I teach a class.

My feature teaching preference would be to continue with the classes I have already taught, and there are plenty of them, 11. My strength and preference is data science classes, but also happiness class that aligns with my research. I was also developing a new class "social indicators" that would be broader than just happiness and include topics such as trust, freedom, and meaning. This would also align with my editorial position at social indicators research journal.

I am interested in teaching short courses / microcredentials. I have already taught a short GIS course⁸ informally twice, for my colleagues from the department and other faculty from Arts and Sciences; and for Walter Rand Institute. But I would like to teach

⁸<https://theaok.github.io/shortGIS/>

other short courses and more often. There is an initiative to create Microcredentials and Digital Badges—I would like to participate in it.

3 Service

My service mostly builds on and derives from my main focus and strength, research. I provide such service in two main ways: 1) to the profession/scholarly field, and 2) to students.

I review about 3-4/mo or 36-48/year papers for journals, including the top journals such as Journal of Personality and Social Psychology and Public Administration Review (see appendix for details). Reviewing is an essential foundation of scholarly fields, and it is increasingly in short supply—something I can attest to as an editor of a journal. Since January 2024, I co-edit Social Indicators Research, the leading journal in my field of quality of life and wellbeing. My editorial philosophy is to be mentor and helper, not just gate-keeper—for instance, I am often in favor of revision prior to external review, and I try to guide the authors, especially the junior ones.⁹

My research-oriented service over past 6 years 2020-2026 to students is: published 10 peer-reviewed articles with students as co-authors [!!!??TODO adding current sir paper flexi work hours rubia ebshey lonnie], supervised 8 dissertations (4 graduated; 4 in-progress), served on 11 dissertation committees, supervised 6 data science master theses, served on 2 master thesis committees in other social science, and supervised 15 independent studies. I have also led brown bag seminars and organized a workshop on academic publishing.

And I am very excited about bringing to campus an award winning¹⁰ junior professor from Germany as a visiting scholar for 2 months in Fall 2026: Leonie C. Steckermeier¹¹. Leonie is a productive scholar not only benefiting my research, but also already 2 of our doctoral students¹²

I contribute service to the campus and department. Over 2018-2022 I have led the development of a new MS in data science and associated certificate program. This was a substantial undertaking and also somewhat challenging as the newly created programs are located outside of my home department. I have been serving since 2022 as a director for data science certificate.¹³

sep 2025 - jul 2026 20hrs per week; supervised 2 courtesy appointment to work as a Volunteer Researcher in the Department of Public Policy Raman And Dhayra work with me on research but also helped students in my class.

I frequently serve as both ad hoc chair and member on Advancement and Promotions (A&P) committee. I find this service fulfilling. I contribute to promoting quality faculty in our social sciences and I learn about my colleagues. Usual committee service is enumerated on the CV.

While research-oriented service is my strength and passion, and usual campus and departmental service is my duty, I am also mindful of Rutgers-Camden public and community service mission. I agree that as a public university, we also need to provide service to the public and community. I have assisted a number of Rutgers-Camden students in their community projects over past 5 years serving as a faculty advisor for, for instance: Olorunfunmi Adebajo's internship at the Camden County Community Development Office's Homelessness Assistance Unit,¹⁴ Marlo Rossi's project at Walter Rand Institute and other projects on abortion,¹⁵; and Ojobo Agbo Eje: "Camden Health Equity Data Visualization Initiative" project.¹⁶

New Jersey first, but I have been civically engaged outside of the Garden State as well. For instance, I have used my data management skills to assist with data collection and management for Ohio Business Round Table, and Michigan Economic Competitiveness Study.

In the ideal world, I would like to continue with research-oriented service. In particular, I would like to increase my research group

⁹I am grateful to the editor of Journal of Applied Psychology who has guided me when I was a junior author.

¹⁰ISQOLS Prize for the Best Dissertation on Quality of Life, Well being, and Happiness, 2nd prize, 2023; Best PhD Dissertation of the Faculty of Human Sciences, Dissertation Award of the Otto von Guericke University Magdeburg for outstanding research achievements in the context of the dissertation, 2022; Second prize of the Fritz Thyssen Foundation for the best social science paper in German for the article "Eine Krise der sozialen Anerkennung? Ergebnisse einer Bevölkerungsbefragung zu Alltagserfahrungen der Wert- und Geringschätzung in Deutschland.", 2019

¹¹<https://scholar.google.com/citations?user=xjkPThwAAAAJ&hl=de>

¹²Michael J. D'Italia is our recent PhD graduate, and Erick E. Watt-Udogu our current PhD student—we have monthly or so zoom meetings where we are already working on papers.

¹³See certificates at the bottom of the page: <https://graduateschool.camden.rutgers.edu/graduate-programs>

¹⁴News item: <https://patimes.org/from-research-to-county-strategy-how-negative-learning-shaped-camden-countys-shared-housing-innovation>

¹⁵News item: <https://theconversation.com/abortion-laws-show-that-public-policy-doesnt-always-line-up-with-public-opinion-274699>

¹⁶News item: <https://camden.rutgers.edu/news/rutgers-camdens-urban-innovation-fund-fuels-transformative-community-projects>

and co-author more with students, and ideally postdocs. Chairing dissertations and leading independent studies would be also my strength and preference. I'm happy to take on more administrative duties such as co-editing another journal.

4 Appendix

4.1 Research

4.1.1 Notes/Footnotes

note: this book is excluded from the promotion packet (this is a popular science book): Happiness and Place: Cities v Nature. Why Life is Better Outside of the City? Palgrave Macmillan

Unlike in many (most?) other cases, my external letters are likely to be non-US. Note that Europeans and other non-US nationals are more objective and don't suffer from grade inflation—this should be taken into account when comparing to overly enthusiastic positively biased US evaluations. For instance, European "bad" or "poor" is equivalent to US "adequate", "passable", and European "good" would mean in the US "extraordinary" or "outstanding."

I am collegial and collaborative—I've coauthored with over 20 authors (Scopus): <https://www.scopus.com/authid/detail.uri?authorId=23061538900#tab=co-authors>

4.1.2 Elaboration On My Research

4.1.3 Scientometrics

As per Google Scholar https://scholar.google.com/citations?hl=en&user=pz9RYloAAAAJ&view_op=list_works&sortby=pubdate: I have more than doubled my citations since 2017, when I have submitted my materials for promotion to associate professor with tenure, from 163 to 353 in 2025.

According to Scopus <https://www.scopus.com/authid/detail.uri?authorId=23061538900>: I have had about 4 indexed publications per year since 2017, and also my citations more than doubled between 2017 and 2025.

My H-index (Google Scholar) is 28, while already 15-20 is considered a standard for going up to full. Per Hirsch: H-index of 20 after 20 years of scientific activity, characterizes a successful scientist <https://beckerguides.wustl.edu/c.php?g=299569&p=2001203#:~:text=Per%20Hirsch:,universities%20or%20major%20research%20laboratories>.

Scores between 15 and 20 about right for coming a full professor: <https://techniumscience.com/index.php/technium/hindex#:~:text=Publication%20and%20citation%20patterns%20differ,for%20coming%20a%20full%20professor>.

H-index of 15 to 20 is a good standard for appointment to full professor: <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC10025721/#:~:text=However%2C%20an%20h%2Dindex%20of,for%20appointment%20to%20full%20professor>.

4.2 Teaching

address low swb class eval bc on angela like cp paste all verbal stuff from 3 students incl 2 paraguay, and from my response to patrice;
see notes in n.oorg in tenure/assoc-to-full

4.3 Letters from students

One highlight is that the skills learned in the classes work in the real world: "The classes I took with you are helping not only my scholarship, but my day job. Thank you [...] I greatly appreciate it." and "subject:Received a Job Offer [...] I would like to thank you for all of the guidance and knowledge during all of your data-related courses the past several semesters to help me get to the point I am at today."

And my classes might have even contributed to retention in the program: ""I have learnt so much about my region is really unbelievable and I have enjoyed working with you a lot. So much, I am actually considering STAYING in the program because of you!"

From:
Sent: Wednesday, April 8, 2026 12:19 AM
To: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <ao264@camden.rutgers.edu>
Subject: Fw: SEVIS Data Pull 4/6/2026 - Fall 2026

Dr. Adam,

I would be remiss if I didn't share that my day job includes working in Python all the time. The Director of the Office of International Students sends an Excel file each week that is essentially a data dump, and I've used all three of the classes I took with you to make sense of it each time. Without what I learned in your classes, it would just be a random Excel file - and I like Excel. This is just a small piece of it - I was emailing late into the night with her about ban lists and communication strategy, and that entire conversation would not have been possible without the visualizations.

I also create the attached HTML, which I share each week with my colleagues, and we've been relying on it for real decision-making. The HTML is about 85% for me - I regularly echo your point about adding notes to the data. That's what people talk about more than the visuals. They look at the charts, but they look forward to my notes.

I really appreciate everything I learned in your classes and your guidance in both my professional and academic work.

From:
Sent: Wednesday, January 21, 2026 11:21 AM
The classes I took with you are helping not only my scholarship, but my day job. Thank you.
Again, thank you for sharing your knowledge and mentorship. I greatly appreciate it.

indep stu dec18 2025
Hi Professor,

I really appreciate it! Thank you so much!

Again, I am truly grateful to have been a student of yours and learn so much from you.

Have an amazing holiday!

J

2024-04-26 Fri gmail "Dissertation development credit issue and thank you"
Also - thank you. I realize that I have spent so much time this semester focusing on what I needed to do that I neglected to ever tell you how grateful I have been for our work together. I know that I can be a real pain in the ass, and you have definitely experienced that more than anyone else at Rutgers - six credits of courses with me and chairing my dissertation committee! Please know that I deeply appreciate everything you have done for me, and I recognize the many ways you have helped me grow as a scholar and, frankly, as an agentic person in general. I am truly grateful for you.

<2024-04-21 Sun> gmail: class "Completed sections"
"I have learnt so much about my region is really unbelievable and I have enjoyed working with you a lot. So much, I am actually considering STAYING in the program because of you!"

sp22 swb May 12 at 15:30pm
Hi, Dr. Adam. Here are the materials of my final work. I follow the instructions of JPAM style. The word document may not be as neat as the PDF one due to some technical issues. I am excited that it is my first quantitative paper, although

there is still a long way from publication. Thank you so much for you help! Your classes have improved me a lot. I had never thought about being able to use these knowledges before taking your classes. Thank you!

Besides, could we keep working on this paper during this summer? It will be my great honor to make a publishment with you.

from:
to:Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date:Jun 25, 2018, 8:26 PM
subject:Received a Job Offer

Dr. Okulicz-Kozaryn,

I would like to thank you for all of the guidance and knowledge during all of your data-related courses the past several semesters to help me get to the point I am at today.

I was extended an offer with the Philadelphia School District as a Strategy Analyst with their Charter School Office. The office itself oversees Philadelphia's 84 charter schools (and 70k+ students). I will be doing a lot with the student level data in regard to performance/monitoring and helping with policy/research.

Thanks Again.

4.4 Service

Reviewing for journals: journals and counts are in the CV on p. 4: https://theaok.github.io/okulicz_kozaryn_cv.pdf#page=4